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APPS



The best dating apps aren't even dating apps

Amanda Silberling

10:40 AM PDT · July 31, 2025

It's no longer taboo to meet your partner on the internet. The evidence is everywhere: It's on your refrigerator door, where you've hung up the wedding invitations of friends who met on Tinder. It's on your Instagram feed, where a friend shares a sappy post about her one-year anniversary with a woman she met on Hinge.

But when Zeke Rothfels tells people that she met her husband online, she's not talking about swiping left until she finally found the right guy. She's talking about cultivating a relationship across the U.S.-Canada border with a man she met in a Facebook meme group.

"I think we both felt kind of like, is this crazy?" Rothfels told TechCrunch. "Do I acknowledge that this feels like something, or will that ruin it?"

It was crazy, but it was also real — six years later, Rothfels is reminiscing about meeting her husband after she's just put their 2-year-old child to sleep.

Everyone is tired of dating apps. This mass [disillusionment](#) has sent the stocks of dating giants [tumbling](#). The stock prices of Bumble and Match Group — the company behind 45 dating apps, including Tinder, Hinge, and OkCupid — have declined about [90%](#) and [68%](#) over the last five years,

respectively.

Together, these companies have shed [\\$40 billion](#) in market cap since 2021, struggling to capture the attention of Gen Z users.



“Do I acknowledge that this feels like something, or will that ruin it?”

But the internet’s presence in our social lives won’t just disappear. As singles [grow weary](#) of swiping, couples are getting to know each other on traditional social media sites — in the Tumblr “Ask” box, in Reddit DMs, and even on [newer platforms like Bluesky](#).

People may not turn to social media with the intent to find love, but these online spaces naturally forge connections, and sometimes, those connections grow beyond friendship. Here, people are no longer at the mercy of dating apps’ mysterious algorithms and emphasis on physical appearance, nor do they have to face an inexplicable number of [fish photos](#). It makes these unexpected digital “meet-cutes” look more appealing than updating your Tinder profile again.

Swipe fatigue

By 2013, online dating had become the most popular way for heterosexual couples in America to meet, according to the longstanding “[How Couples Meet and Stay Together](#)” study from Stanford. By 2019, about 40% of heterosexual couples had [met online](#), doubling the number of couples who met through friends.

Today, about 30% of all American adults have used dating apps, a figure that [increases](#) to 52% among never-married adults.

With broader adoption, however, people were exposed to the darker sides of dating online. Seven out of 10 online daters said it’s common to [encounter people lying](#) on their profiles, and 66% of women ages 18 to 49 reported being harassed, [according to Pew Research](#). Another 56% said they were sent sexually explicit images they didn’t ask for.

Over time, people began to feel that their experiences on dating apps had become more frustrating than hopeful, and the future of the dating app

giants was called into question.

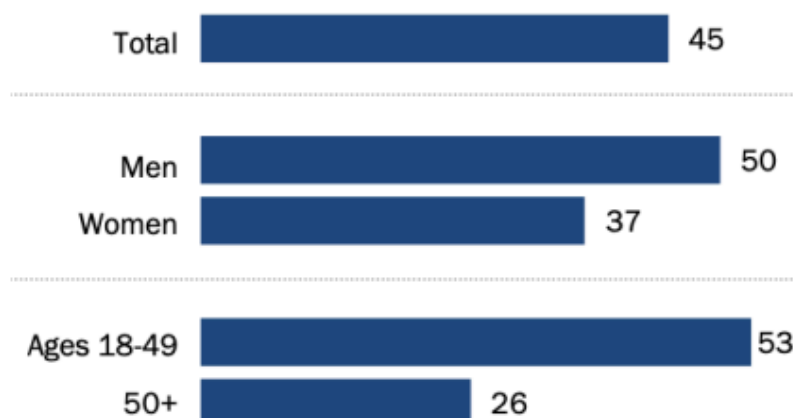
Meanwhile, discouraged dating app users have begun to create online whisper networks where they can discover if others have had negative experiences with their date. The trend started on [“Are we dating the same guy?”-style](#) Facebook Groups, where women would post screenshots of potential dates’ profiles to find out if they were already seeing someone else.

The same concept also powers the newly viral dating advice app [Tea](#), which claims to have 1.6 million users. Its sudden popularity has fueled online debate, where men accuse women of doxxing them, and women point to the necessity of sharing these warnings with others. After all, dating apps largely ignored serious safety concerns, like background checks, according to a 2019 [investigative report by ProPublica and Columbia Journalism Investigations](#), which highlighted the presence of sexual predators on Match-owned dating apps.

Yet the solutions are often as bad as the problems they try to fix. Tea, for example, has seen its security breached twice, with [users’ selfies, private](#)

45% of adults who are ‘single and looking’ have used a dating platform in past year, but this varies by age, gender

Among U.S. adults who are ‘single and looking,’ % who say they have used a dating site or app in the past year



Note: “Single and looking” refers to adults who are not married, living with a partner or in a committed romantic relationship and who are looking for a committed romantic relationship or casual dates. Those who did not give an answer or who gave other responses are not shown.

Source: Survey of U.S. adults conducted July 5-17, 2022.

“From Looking for Love to Swiping the Field: Online Dating in the U.S.”

PEW RESEARCH CENTER

IMAGE CREDITS: PEW RESEARCH CENTER



IMAGE CREDITS: SCREENSHOT OF FACEBOOK BY TECHCRUNCH

[messages, and government IDs shared to 4chan](#), a notorious web forum.

It's not surprising, then, that some are giving up online dating altogether.

The new “meeting online”

Rothfels didn't mean to fall in love with a guy from a Facebook meme group who lived in another country. The internet had other plans.

“I always thought he was hot,” Rothfels concedes. “I liked his mustache.”

These [absurdist communities](#), mostly populated with quick-witted, offbeat college students, often had thousands of members. Rothfels and her husband, Owen, had only interacted in passing, but she knew that they had similar senses of humor and political views — otherwise, they wouldn't have both spent so much time in these online spaces.

Owen lived in Minneapolis, and she lived in Toronto, so she never acted on her idle crush. Then one morning in 2019, while she was hungover in bed after a party, she saw that Owen had posted on Instagram about the folk musician Woody Guthrie.

“I replied saying that I'm related to Woody Guthrie, which is true — distantly — and he replied saying, ‘Marry me,’” she said. “That exchange kind of kicked off us talking constantly for the next week ... We basically never stopped messaging each other.”

Though their connection blossomed beyond their shared interest in “elaborate dadaist memes,” the whimsical foundation of their relationship had proven to be the ultimate icebreaker.

“The knowledge that we had both spent a lot of time online making these dumb memes made it less daunting,” Rothfels said.

Elsewhere, demand for alternative ways to meet people is [growing](#), like going to in-person [speed dating](#) events or [mixers](#), turning to [older methods like personal ads](#), [trying apps for offline dating](#), or even joining running clubs, which have become a [weirdly popular](#) avenue for dating.

But like Rothfels, people are finding love in unexpected places — the forums and sites they use to pass idle time online, as opposed to those dedicated to online dating. There, they get to know each other in shared social settings,

where the specter of possible romance doesn't haunt each of their interactions from the first message.

Rudy, a 54-year-old who had never used traditional dating apps, met his wife by chance in an erotic pen pals forum on Reddit, where their identities were obscured by their personas of mythical creatures.

“There's a great deal of safety thrown into those interactions, at least on Reddit,” Rudy (using a pseudonym) told TechCrunch. “Throwaway Reddit accounts are effectively anonymous.”



I think that Twitter has changed how we communicate and has definitely changed how we relate to other people ... on Twitter, you could be dropping lore every five seconds.

Within their fantastical world, they wrote hundreds of thousands of words to each other, solely because they found it fun. Over the course of a year and a half, their fictional correspondence slowly became more real.

“We explained it as a creative writing forum,” Rudy said. “My family is aware that I met her [online]; they're just not aware that it was explicitly pornographic, ‘Cthulhu mythos’ stuff.”

Explicit flirtations aside, their creative connection allowed them to get to know each other on a deeper level. Over time, they revealed details about their real lives, and they decided to meet in person. Soon, the woman who became Rudy's wife moved to the U.S. to be with him.

“My wife's wit and cleverness ... She makes me laugh more than anybody, and I believe it's the same for her,” Rudy told TechCrunch. “When we wrote, we wrote lots of poetry together and things like that. That just becomes a connection — we were locked in before we'd ever had any romantic encounter.”

Developing a connection with a friend — even an internet friend — can help speed up the “getting to know you” process that typically comes with online dating, which users have begun to [describe as “admin work”](#) or [a second job](#).

In contrast with dating apps, this way of meeting more naturally mimics the feel of meeting through friends.

James Cassar, a writer in their 30s, found a similar sense of common ground with their partner Nicole. The couple originally met on Twitter, where they followed each other because they posted about the same niche rock bands.

When they later matched on Tinder, they already recognized each other from the internet, allowing them to skip the small talk.

“When Nicole looked at my Tinder, she was like, ‘You like Cheem? I don’t know anyone that listens to Cheem,’ and I was like, ‘Then you must know that I’m that person [from Twitter],’” Cassar told TechCrunch. “It’s like a weird CAPTCHA — like, which underground indie band do you like?”

Though they had never spoken, they already knew a lot about each other, since they had been reading each other’s posts for years. And often, people are more open about their thoughts and feelings when they’re posting semi-anonymously to a crowd of internet strangers.

“I think that Twitter has changed how we communicate and has definitely changed how we relate to other people,” Cassar said. “It bypasses a lot of the social contract of like, ‘Oh, I’m gonna meet somebody in person, and we’re gonna get a coffee or something, and then I’m not gonna tell them this embarrassing thing about me until seven or eight dates in.’ Whereas on Twitter, you could be dropping lore every five seconds.”

With the internet permeating so much of our everyday lives, the separation between online and offline relationships can blur.

Recently, when a friendly stranger asked how I met my boyfriend, I was prepared to offer my canned version of the story: We were close friends for seven years, and after our friends pestered us about it long enough, we finally got together.



The internet provides beautiful connections of all sorts, all the time.

My boyfriend’s answer was a bit more blunt.

“We met on a meme page,” he said.

With some surprise and amusement, I realized that his version of events was correct, too.

While we did start dating after many years of friendship, we first became friends because we were both moderators of a local Facebook meme group in 2017. We crossed paths in the irony-laden halls of [“weird Facebook,”](#) the same collection of esoteric meme groups where Zeke and Owen met.

“There’s always a responsible distance that people should put between their presence online and themselves,” Rudy said. “But I think the internet provides beautiful connections of all sorts, all the time.”

It’s a bit weirder than meeting on Hinge, but so far, it’s working.

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Dating app Hinge is ditching the Facebook login requirement

Sarah Perez — 1:29 PM PDT · June 1, 2018

[Hinge](#), the dating app that [promised](#) a better set of prospects by suggesting matches who share Facebook friends, is about to radically change its course: it's ditching its requirement that users log in with Facebook. The change will go into effect on Monday, June 5th on Android, followed by a June 12th release on iOS.

While the option to use Facebook won't be fully removed, users will instead be able to choose to authenticate using their phone number, the company says.

The decision was prompted by ongoing requests from users who have asked for a non-Facebook login option, Hinge founder and CEO Justin McLeod says. This is especially important to the company as people "move away from Facebook and onto other platforms," he notes.

This may refer to younger users' preference for different social platforms, as reflected by a [Pew Internet survey released this week](#), which found that

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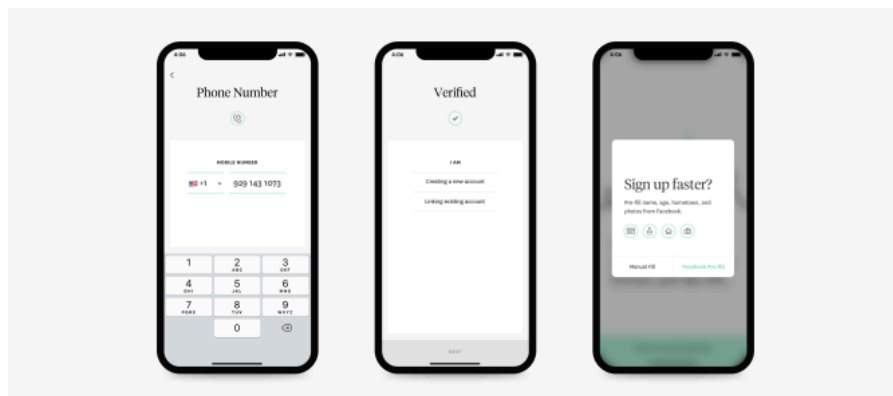
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teens are dumping Facebook proper for YouTube, Snapchat and (Facebook-owed) Instagram.

But Hinge isn't the first dating app to go this route. Bumble [also recently said](#) it was removing the Facebook requirement, in response to user feedback.



Hinge

In Hinge's case, however, the decision changes the dating app's fundamental value proposition, which was focused on matching singles with people they were already connected to by way of Facebook friends, up to three degrees away. The premise was that this would make online dating feel less creepy. And, because you shared mutual friends, you'd be less concerned that the person was a total nut.

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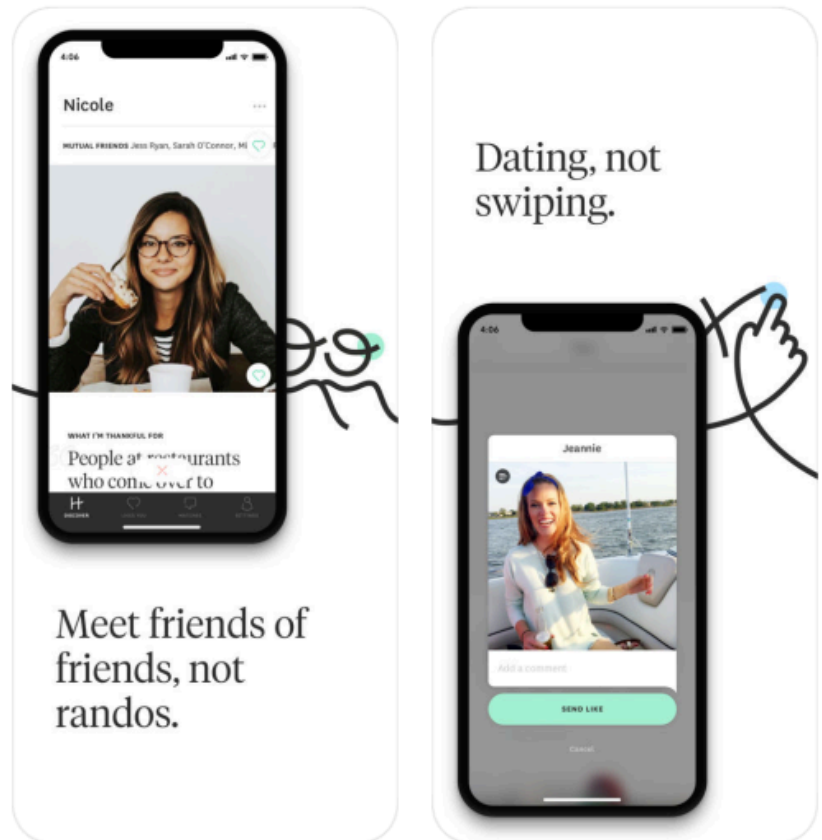
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This also helped Hinge stand out in a space that’s dominated by Tinder, which could often seem random and filled with those not in search of “real relationships,” let’s say.

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ocused down on this brand position with call-outs

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since shut down.)

It's unclear how well these moves have paid off for Hinge in the long run, as the company won't share user numbers. It will only say the active member base has doubled since the beginning of the year. However, Sensor Tower estimates Hinge has more than 3 million worldwide downloads across both iOS and Android, 94 percent of which are in the U.S.

The removal of the Facebook requirement, not at all coincidentally, comes at an interesting time for dating app businesses in general, which have just learned Facebook now aims to compete with them directly.

In May, Facebook announced [a new dating feature](#) that would allow people to meet non-friends. Hinge took notice, as did others.

"Facebook Dating Looks a Whole Lot Like Hinge," [wrote Wired](#), for example.

Our team watching the [#f8](#) conference:
pic.twitter.com/vCwP3qpgzE

— Hinge (@hinge) [May 1, 2018](#)

"It's interesting to see a company facing so many privacy concerns enter one of the most intimate spaces in tech today," McLeod says of Facebook's

dating plans. “We’re flattered they chose to copy our designs, but ultimately we’re not worried about them as a competitor – our members are increasingly moving away from Facebook as a platform.”

Burn.

The updated Hinge app will offer users three ways to use Hinge: 1) they can continue to log in with Facebook as usual, 2) they can log in with their phone number, or 3) they can log in with a phone number, but use an option in the app to import select bio information from Facebook, for convenience.

After filling in the profile, users can disconnect from Facebook without losing the imported information, Hinge notes.

Hinge doesn’t believe the move away from Facebook as the underlying network will have an ill effect. Because of its robust profiles, which allow for the liking of individual pieces of content, it thinks its machine learning algorithms have advanced to the point where they can surpass “friends of friends” as a predictor of compatibility, the CEO says.

“Friends of friends is a symbol for what Hinge truly stands for: humanizing modern dating and fighting against the culture of shallow swiping,” says McLeod. “As the Hinge community continues to grow and evolve, we’re not relying on a single feature to best match our members; instead we’ll remain at the forefront of product development and double down on giving our members’ the best offline experience,” he adds.

It’s not hard to get on board with Hinge’s overall vision, but its app is still dwarfed by Tinder, which is now estimated to have more than 50 million users.

Rival Bumble is growing as well, with some 22 million+ users. And because dating is ultimately a numbers game, Hinge needs the no-Facebook-needed policy to really boost its own.

Topics: [dating](#) [Facebook](#) [Hinge](#)

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Hinge CMO Jackie Jantos hopes to help make Gen Zers less lonely

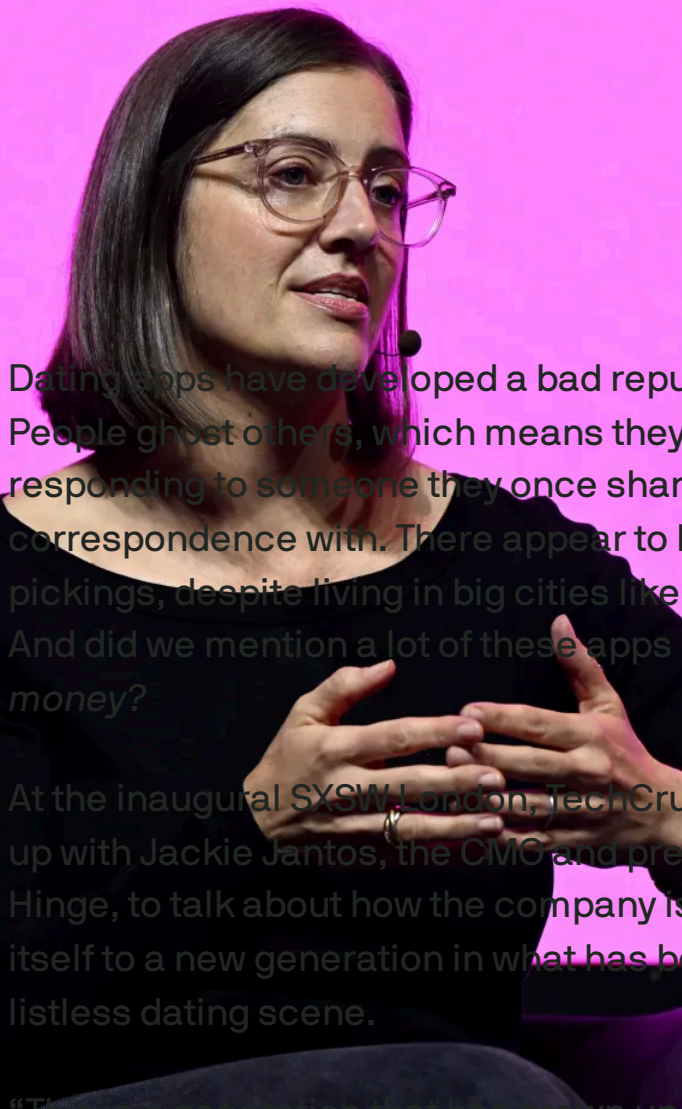


IMAGE CREDITS:

“This is a generation that has grown up with a deep understanding of how digital experiences are created and what they are trying to get out of them,” Jantos said in an interview with TechCrunch. She listed the traits Gen Zers want most out of their brands, like transparency and authenticity. It’s a diverse generation that spends less time in person than its predecessors.

“If you’re not building with inclusion at the center of everything, you’re just not going to build a meaningful product or marketing activation to engage them,” she said.

The dating app landscape has evolved over the past few years, seeing companies like Hinge working overtime to try to attract and sustain user attention.

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Tinder, for example, has struggled [with growth](#) in the past few years, culminating in its CEO stepping down a few weeks ago. Bumble [is also seeing](#) a slowdown in user growth.

Hinge and Tinder are both owned by Match Group. The Q1 2025 report released by Match Group shows that Hinge is faring a bit better than its sister company. The [report showed](#) that Hinge saw an increase in direct revenue, compared to Tinder, and that the app's downloads were "strong" across the English-speaking and Western European markets.

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Jantos said Hinge is implementing and toying around with numerous new features at the moment. For example, it has added a quota on how many chats one person can have at one time so that a user isn't simply "collecting chats."

"We want to encourage people to close out chats if you're not interested in someone," Jantos said, adding that hopefully this encourages people to focus on a smaller number of conversations that can successfully move toward a date. She said Hinge is testing its coaching feature, which looks to give users tips about building their profiles.

The Match Group Q1 2025 report said Hinge was also looking to introduce Warm Introductions soon to "highlight shared interests to improve match quality."

Jantos was coy on details, but said there was a new introduction that would hopefully encourage users to "spend a little more time discovering each profile."

"Our recommendations have gotten really strong with the new AI recommender that we recently released," she added. (Match Group's [Q1 2025 news report](#) said the new feature, launched in March, has already driven a 15% increase in matches and contact exchanges.) Jantos said that Hinge is also hoping to boost its safety features with AI and that overall, tools on the app will "continuously improve because of AI."

"But also new tools will come along the way to coach you along the [dating] journey," she said.

Jantos flew into the inaugural SXSW London to give a talk about the loneliness epidemic impacting Gen

Zers. There is no shortage of stories and reports on how young people are connecting less with the outside world, glued to their phones and virtual realities. Jantos told TechCrunch this is one reason Hinge launched its One More Hour fund in 2023.

The fund seeks to invest \$1 million into organizations to [foster more in-person](#) connections among Gen Zers. She’s heard feedback from young people on her team that there are barriers to hanging out these days, including how expensive it has become and finding places that feel safe.

“We want to lower the barrier so people just want to come out because we know if they build that skill, it’s more likely when they’re on our product, they’ll be more likely to be comfortable meeting someone up for a date,” she said.

And, as expected, Hinge is throwing events, filling ads with creators, such as writers, to “meet the audience where they are.” It created a [zine](#) and campaign about Hinge success stories to hopefully inspire Gen Zers to go find love. And even better, on the Hinge app.

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